close, but we appear to be heading for a heavy defeat, and nobody is smiling at the team briefing.

'Come on, guys,' Graeme says. 'We can do so much better than this.'

The captain is right, of course, but I still don't understand why he has chosen to single me out for criticism in front of the entire squad, especially when I actually did stick it out and batted for a full session; many others didn't. Maybe he knows how I will react. Maybe he knows I will be angry and will want to prove him wrong. In the end, I know he has always backed me and I know he has my best interests at heart.

As soon as the briefing ends, I leave our changing room and walk down the stairs of the famous pavilion at Lord's, passing the stewards in white blazers at the door, turning left, keeping my head down as I stride past happy hordes of England supporters in the Harris Garden, and eventually reach the Grace Gates.

A friend is waiting for me in his car parked on St John's Wood Road and, as I get into the passenger seat, I catch sight of a familiar figure crossing the road immediately in front of us.

'Is that Jeffrey Archer?' I ask.

'I think so, why?'

'I've read all his books. My entire family are all massive fans.'

'Well, go and say hello to him,' says my friend. 'He loves his cricket.'

So I jump out of the car and introduce myself to Lord Archer, who could not have been friendlier. He says he will arrange for a copy of his new book – *A Prisoner of Birth* published a few months earlier – to be delivered to our changing room the next morning. He has regularly sent me his books ever since.

I read most of the 412-page novel during the course of the next two days while sitting on our balcony, in between keeping an eye on the cricket, as we demonstrate fantastic application and courage in adversity. Graeme, Neil and Hash all score centuries as we bat and bat and bat, and ultimately secure a creditable draw.